

# Mark A. Runco & Garrett J. Jaeger

## *The Standard Definition of Creativity — Originality × Effectiveness*

Creativity researchers · Southern Oregon University / Torrance Center legacy

[ portrait ]

Mark A. Runco

"Originality is vital for creativity but is not sufficient."

"Creative ideas are both original and effective."

### 1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Everyone uses the word 'creativity', but few can define it. Runco and Jaeger did the field a service by pinning down the definition almost all researchers now share — originality plus effectiveness — and tracing where it came from. Every other creativity tool rests on this baseline.

### 2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Mark Runco is a leading creativity scholar, long-time editor of the *Creativity Research Journal* and author of the field's standard textbook. Garrett Jaeger is a developmental researcher of creative cognition. Their 2012 paper consolidated a century of scattered definitions.

### 3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

| NAME                    | WHAT IT IS                                                      |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Standard Definition | Creativity = originality (novelty) + effectiveness (usefulness) |
| Originality criterion   | The idea must be novel, surprising or uncommon                  |
| Effectiveness criterion | The idea must be useful, fit or valuable to the task            |
| Bipartite structure     | Both criteria are necessary; neither alone suffices             |
| Definitional lineage    | Traced to Stein (1953), Barron, and mid-century scholars        |

### 4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Use both criteria as a gate: is the idea novel AND useful?
- Reject 'novel but useless' and 'useful but derivative' as non-creative
- Apply the definition to set clear evaluation criteria for ideas
- Distinguish creativity (ideas) from innovation (implementation)
- Anchor teaching and assessment on a shared, defensible definition

### 5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Definition is deliberately minimal — says little about process
- 'Effectiveness' is context-dependent and hard to measure
- Threshold for 'original' varies by domain and observer
- Says nothing about how creativity is produced
- Debate continues over adding 'surprise' as a third criterion

### 6 ENDURING IMPACT

- The most-cited modern definition of creativity
- Standard reference in creativity research and teaching
- Gives educators a defensible assessment baseline
- Underpins the novelty/usefulness logic of ideation tools
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Unit 1 definition of creativity

### SELECTED WORKS

#### THE STANDARD DEFINITION OF CREATIVITY

*Creativity Research Journal*

RUNCO & JAEGER · 2012

#### CREATIVITY: THEORIES & THEMES

*Research, Development, Practice*

RUNCO · 2014

#### CREATIVITY RESEARCH JOURNAL

*Editor (long-serving)*

RUNCO · ongoing

#### THE CREATIVITY RESEARCH HANDBOOK

*Hampton Press*

RUNCO (ed.) · 1997

### REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Runco, M.A. and Jaeger, G.J. (2012) 'The Standard Definition of Creativity', *Creativity Research Journal*, 24(1), pp. 92–96.

Runco, M.A. (2014) *Creativity: Theories and Themes*. 2nd edn. San Diego: Academic Press.